MINDHOLA RIVER BRIDGE, Tapi

JUN. 2023

A portion of the two-year-old ready-to-inaugurate bridge crumbled, sending shockwaves as it was to open for vehicular traffic soon. Surat-based contractor Akshay Construction was **blacklisted for using substandard materials** and several senior engineers involved in the project were suspended

No loss of life

BHOGAVO RIVER BRIDGE, Surendranagar

SEPT. 2023

A portion of the 40-year-old bridge near Wadhwan city fell down when a 40-tonne dumper attempted to cross. **No action was taken** as signs banning heavy vehicles were put up

4 injured

UNDER-CONSTRUCTION FLYOVER, Palanpur

OCT. 2023

Two girders of the overbridge near the RTO Circle collapsed due to **substandard material used.** Case of culpable homicide not amounting to murder filed against four engineers and directors of the contracting agency GPC Infrastructure

1 killed, 2 injured

HABIYASAR CHOTILA BRIDGE, Surendranagar

AUG. 2024

The 5-year-old small bridge in Habiyasar village collapsed after a sudden water discharge from a dam. Fortunately, the road had been closed to traffic. The sarpanch claimed he had raised **concerns about its construction quality**, but the contractor had dismissed them

No casualties

OVER THE PAST THREE YEARS, AT LEAST SIX BRIDGES HAVE COLLAPSED, LEAVING MORE THAN 160 PEOPLE DEAD

bridge fell apart, local politicians and villagers produced multiple documents to show how its unsafe condition was brought to the notice of local authorities, but no action was taken. Officials confide that 'some repairs were done', but locals claim they only filled a few gaps superficially while the much-needed structural repairs were ignored.

Experts point out that there were many tell-tale signs of deterioration that appear to have been overlooked. "Asset management is extremely essential," says Yash Majeethia, treasurer, Gujarat Institute of Civil Engineers and Architects (GICEA). "About a decade ago, most trucks were two- or three-axle vehicles, often carrying loads even up to 1.5x their capacity, causing uneven stress on bridges. While overloading is better regulated today, it still occurs with two-, three- and multi-axle trucks. Many existing bridges were not originally designed for such loads and, without regular maintenance, the risks naturally increase."

An industry veteran says regular maintenance and alert engineers can prevent such disasters, but the 'culture' of late is to focus on new infrastructure rather than maintain existing assets. "Financial allocation, too, is insufficient. Ideally, 1 per cent of project cost should be reserved for maintenance, but only around 0.5 per cent is. The original contractor's defect liability period of the new asset is usually five years, so he does only the bare minimum for the asset to stay afloat till then. Thereafter, the new contractor cuts corners as maintenance contracts are not high-value. This is where effective government oversight can make a difference," he says.

But the case of Hatkeshwar flyover, inaugurated in Ahmedabad in 2017, the source of much embarrassment to the government, set new lows in exposing systemic flaws. The contractor's defect liability period was only one year. Within four years, severe damage to the structure was reported and, by May 2022, it was deemed unfit for use. Since then, its fate has been hanging in the balance. Built at a cost of Rs 34 crore, the flyover will be demolished for Rs 3.9 crore, to be recovered from the original contractor, and is expected to be rebuilt for around Rs 52 crore.

SHADOW OPERATORS

For contractors, blacklisting is a real threat, but there are several instances of them finding a way around the punishment. In the Hatkeshwar controversy, original contractors—Ajay Engineering Infrastructure Pvt. Ltd and PMC SGS India Pvt. Ltd—were blacklisted. But other public infrastructure projects awarded to the former were not withdrawn till media outcry forced the authorities' hand.

Besides, sources say, it is an open secret that a blacklisted firm starts operations in another name. "The solution is not to blacklist the firm, but blacklist the operator, so that his corrupt nexus breaks," an insider says. Add to this the cartel of a dozen odd civil contractors who dominate public construction projects by bidding 10-15 per cent below tender cost. "This is the first red flag," says Vatsal Patel, a technical consultant and past president of GICEA. "Hence, we want to recommend to the government to bring in a system to award contracts not to the lowest bidder, but the second lowest bidder."

Interestingly, a contractor dismisses the cost of corruption as only '5-6 per cent' of the total project cost. "We can work well within that," says a retired engineer. "But projects turn out to be of such poor quality because the entire government system is so lax that contractors get away with more theft out of sheer greed. It is a reflection on the society. Be it the engineers or contractors, their responsibility of ensuring even basic safety of commuters has gone missing." In Gujarat's crumbling infrastructure, the foundations most eroded are those of governance. ■